The Pack Rat

Definitive Player Walkthrough & Secret Cheat Guide

Author: Authentic 1992 Preservation Team • Platform: PC / Web Retro Revival • 16 Levels Complete

1. Introduction: The Labyrinth Beyond the Living Room

In 1992, Steve Blanding released *The Pack Rat*, a deceptively deep puzzle-platformer. On its surface, the game seems like a straightforward obstacle course where a clever rodent scampers past snapping mousetraps, coils around thread spools, and slides ice blocks to collect cheese.

However, hidden beneath the floorboards lies an intricate, branching network of **16 interconnected stages**:

- **10 Main Campaign Levels (Levels 1–10)**: The primary house gauntlet leading from the lower foundations up through the perilous attic and kitchen.
- **5 Secret Bonus Levels (Levels 11–15)**: Elusive subterranean chambers packed with bonus cheese, coins, and warp passages that bypass treacherous gauntlets.
- **1 Grand Finale (Level 16)**: The ultimate high-voltage laboratory where the true ending awaits.

The Golden Rule of The Pack Rat

The original 1992 game manual teased: *"Not everything is what it seems. Some things on the screen are illusionary. You can walk right through illusionary bricks and you will not be killed by illusionary water."* This guide reveals every false wall, harmless pool, and decoy trap with human landmarks and clear visual routes.

2. Master Level Progression Flowchart

Unlike traditional linear platformers, *The Pack Rat* branches dramatically. Reaching the true ending requires choosing the right mouse holes and avoiding deceptive loops that dump you back at the beginning of the house!

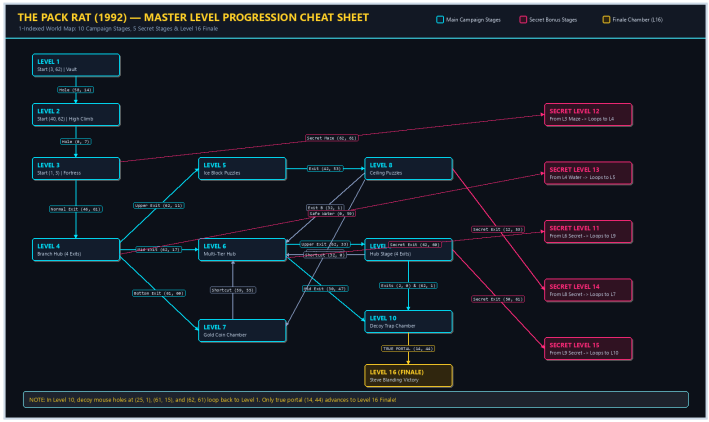


Figure 1: The Complete 16-Level Progression Network (1-Indexed)

2.1 Progression Architecture

1. **The Spine (Levels 1 → 2 → 3 → 4)**: Every playthrough begins in Level 1 and advances linearly through Level 4.
2. **The Level 4 Crossroad**: Level 4 is the grand crossroads of the game. Depending on which mouse hole you enter, you can warp directly to Level 5 (Upper Exit), Level 6 (Middle Exit), Level 7 (Lower Exit), or the secret safe-water tunnel to Level 13!
3. **The Convergence on Level 10**: All paths eventually funnel into Level 10 (The Electrical Machine Chamber).
4. **The Decoy Danger in Level 10**: In Level 10, three mouse holes are **decoys** that punish the player by resetting them back to Level 1! Only the hidden high-voltage portal in the central generator room grants access to the **Level 16 Finale**.

3. The 4 Major Secrets & Illusionary Passages

Every secret location below has been verified against the original 1992 DOS real-mode binary data. Clear side-by-side cards provide immediate visual reference alongside step-by-step navigation.

SECRET 1: LEVEL 1 — THE SUBTERRANEAN CHEESE VAULT

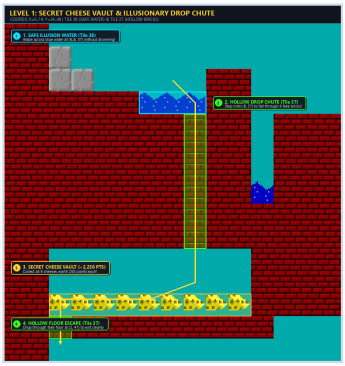


Figure 2: **Fig 3.1:** Safe Water Trench & Hollow Brick Chute

Environment: Living Room Floor • **Destination:** Secret Vault (+1,500 pts)

Landmark:	Begin at spawn on the bottom-left brick floor. Climb staggered ledges along the left wall to the upper reservoir.
The Illusion:	A blue water pool sits at the upper ledge. Unlike normal deep water, this pool is **illusionary water** and will not drown you!
The Route:	Step into the water pool → walk directly through the solid brick pillar on the right (hollow chute) → drop down into vault.
Reward:	Collect 5 cheese wedges and gold coins worth over 1,500 bonus points.
Escape:	Step onto the floor tile at bottom-left of the vault. It is a one-way false floor dropping you back to start.

SECRET 2: LEVEL 3 — THE 118-TILE SOLID BRICK FORTRESS MAZE

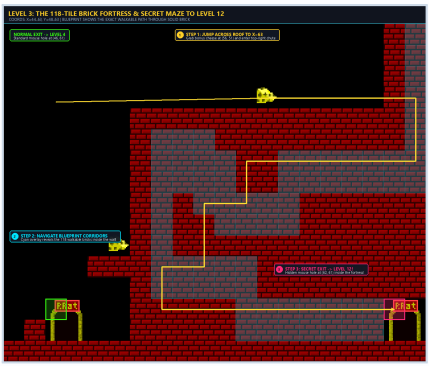


Figure 3: **Fig 3.2:** The 118-Tile Hollow Brick S-Curve Passage

Environment: Brick Basement • **Destination:** Warp to Secret Level 12

Landmark:	Proceed across Level 3 to the far bottom-right corner. You will encounter a massive, towering wall of solid red brick.
The Illusion:	In reality, an astonishing **118 brick tiles** in this fortress are completely hollow and permeable!
The Route:	Walk straight into the brick wall along the floor line. Follow the highlighted cyan path: ascend the interior hidden stairway, weave rightward past the structural column, and descend into the sanctum.
Reward:	Hidden mouse hole warps directly into **Secret Bonus Level 12 (Crystal Caves)**!

SECRET 3: LEVEL 4 — THE SAFE ILLUSIONARY WATER CHANNEL

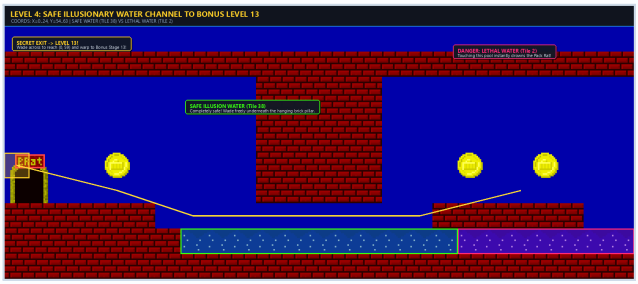


Figure 4: **Fig 3.3:** Safe Shallow Trench vs Lethal Deep Water

Environment: Flooded Foundations • **Destination:** Warp to Secret Level 13

Landmark:	Drop down to the flooded basement floor in the bottom-left quadrant of Level 4.
The Illusion:	The first 11 water tiles extending rightward from the left wall are **illusionary shallow water**. The Pack Rat wades freely without taking damage!
The Danger:	To the right of the safe zone lies true deep water. Touching the deep water causes instant drowning death.
The Route:	Wade leftward through the safe trench to the far left wall. Enter the mouse hole nestled against the rock face.
Reward:	Warps directly to **Secret Bonus Level 13 (Sunken Cellar)**.

SECRET 4: LEVEL 10 — DECOY PITFALL TRAP vs. TRUE FINALE PORTAL

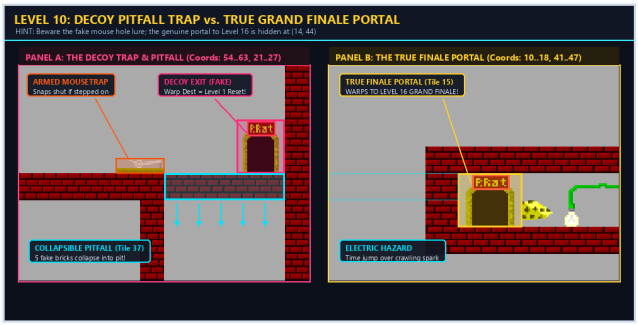


Figure 5: **Fig 3.4:** Decoy Pitfall Trap (Panel A) vs True Finale Portal (Panel B)

Environment: High-Voltage Machine • **Destination:** True Finale Warp (Level 16)

The Trap:	In the upper-right chamber sits an enticing mouse hole with a P.Rat sign. **It is a deadly lure!** An armed mousetrap guards the walkway, and the floor beneath it consists of **5 collapsible fake bricks** that drop you into the pit!
Penalty:	Entering the decoy hole resets the player back to Level 1!
True Route:	Head down to the central generator chamber (coords: 10..18, 41..47). Time your jump over the slow-crawling spark on the green wire.
Reward:	Enter the genuine mouse hole behind the generator coils to warp to the **Level 16 Grand Finale**!

4. Master 16-Stage Directory & Complete Walkthrough

Stage	Internal	Environment	Primary Route & Objective
Level 1	Level 0	Living Room Floor	Jump rightward across floorboards; avoid bottom pit. Enter mouse hole on right wall. Access Cheese Vault via top-left illusionary pool.
Level 2	Level 1	Pantry & Cupboards	Climb climbing spools upward. Push sliding ice blocks to create stairs. Exit is at far bottom-left.
Level 3	Level 2	Brick Basement	Standard exit is at bottom-middle. Navigate the 118-tile hollow brick fortress on the bottom-right to reach Secret Level 12.
Level 4	Level 3	Flooded Foundations	Multi-exit hub: Top-right leads to L5; Mid-right leads to L6; Bottom-right leads to L7. Safe water trench on bottom-left leads to Secret L13.
Level 5	Level 4	Kitchen Countertops	Bounce on rubber bands across stove burners. Exit hole is at lower-middle right. Leads directly to Level 8.
Level 6	Level 5	Dining Hall & Ledges	Patrol rats on long tables. Upper-right exit leads to Level 9; mid-left exit drops to Level 10; secret exit on far right leads to Secret Level 11.
Level 7	Level 6	Storage Closet	Push thread spools down ramps to crush gaps. Mouse hole at upper-right connects back to Level 6.
Level 8	Level 7	Attic Rafters	High-altitude jumps across hanging beams. Left chimney exit leads to Level 7; right rafter exit loops to Level 6; secret chute leads to Secret L14.
Level 9	Level 8	Fireplace Gauntlet	Dodge vertical embers and soot falls. Upper chimney exit connects directly to Level 10. Far right chimney leads to Secret Level 15.
Level 10	Level 9	High-Voltage Machine	Avoid decoy hole on upper right! Enter the electric generator room on middle-left to activate the True Portal to Level 16.
Level 11	Level 10	Secret Sewer Pipes	Secret bonus level from Level 6. High-speed pipe transport network; loops cleanly back to Level 9.
Level 12	Level 11	Secret Crystal Caves	Secret bonus level from Level 3. Abundant cheese clusters; loops back into Level 6.
Level 13	Level 12	Secret Sunken Cellar	Secret bonus level from Level 4 safe water. Low-gravity water jumps; loops back into Level 5.
Level 14	Level 13	Secret Attic Vault	Secret bonus level from Level 8. Massive coin cache; loops back into Level 7.
Level 15	Level 14	Secret Clock Tower	Secret bonus level from Level 9. Swinging pendulum spools; loops back into Level 10.
Level 16	Level 15	The Grand Finale	The supreme challenge! Timed high-voltage spark gauntlet, precision block slides, and the final Golden Trophy Room!

Table 1: The Complete 16-Stage World Directory

5. Essential Survival Mechanics

1. **Thread Spools (Push & Climb)**:
   - Spools act as solid platforms. Pushing against one causes it to roll smoothly across flat ground until it hits a wall or ledge.
   - When touching a vertical column of spools, hold the **Up** key to climb upward like a ladder, or press **Down** to descend safely one spool at a time.
2. **Rubber Bands (The Trampoline Effect)**:
   - Landing on a red rubber band tile bounces the Pack Rat upward automatically.
   - **Pro Tip**: Holding down the **Jump** button as you strike the rubber band delivers a *Super Trampoline Bounce*, propelling you nearly twice as high!
   - You can jump upward through rubber bands from underneath without hitting your head.
3. **Ice Blocks (The 3-Push Mechanic)**:
   - Transparent ice blocks require **three distinct push hits** while holding the Push button to slide horizontally.
   - Crouching directly on top of an ice block and pressing down three times will dislodge it below you, allowing you to drop into sealed lower chambers.

4. **The Emergency Suicide Key (`K`)**:
    - If you accidentally box yourself in with heavy sliding blocks or get wedged behind one-way drops, press the **K** key to restart the current room without losing your overall game progress.
5. **Testing & Exploration God Mode (`I`)**:
    - Press the **I** key (or click the **GOD** button on the top arcade header) to toggle **Invincibility & Unlimited Lives**.
    - In God Mode, the Pack Rat is completely immune to mousetraps, live electrical currents, deep water pools, and enemy rat patrols, allowing frictionless level inspection and testing.

Pack Rat Preservation Project • Authentic 1992 DOS Reconstruction • Happy Hunting!